

Benjamin Lebrun

PhD in Psychology | Clinical Neuropsychologist | Human-Robot Interaction

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📍 University of Canterbury, New Zealand ✉ benjamin.lebrun@pg.canterbury.ac.nz

Profile

I am a French clinical neuropsychologist with a PhD in Psychology, working at the intersection of social cognition, neuropsychology, and human-robot interaction (HRI). My doctoral research showed that people infer “phantom costs” (perceived hidden risks and ulterior motives) when robots make different kinds of offers without a sufficient and plausible reason, and identified how agent type, autonomy, mind perception, and explanations shape these inferences. Alongside this, I have hands-on clinical experience assessing children and adults’ cognitive profiles.

Education

PhD in Psychology ([Testamur link – PIN code: 2026](#)) Christchurch, NZ
University of Canterbury 2023 – 2026

- Thesis: *The Perception of Phantom Costs in Human-Robot Interaction*.
- Supervisors: Andrew Vonasch and Christoph Bartneck.
- Submitted 31 January 2026; defended 20 May 2026; conferred 25 June 2026.

Master of Integrated Psychology Braga, Portugal
University of Minho 2020 – 2022

- GPA: 4.0/4.0 (or 9.0/9.0).
- Research in cognitive and social psychology using physiological measures (PsychoPy).
- Thesis: *Perceiving Social Beings in Artificial Agents*.
Supervisors: Tatjana Nazir and Adriana Sampaio.

Master of Psychology of Neurocognitive Processes and Affective Sciences Lille, France
University of Lille 2020 – 2022

- GPA: 3.85/4.0 (or 8.432/9.0) ([certificate](#)).
- Training in normal and pathological neurocognitive and affective processes, neuropsychological assessment, and neurophysiological methods (e.g., EEG, physiological recording).
- Qualifies the holder to practise as a neuropsychologist in France.
- Thesis: *Perceiving Social Beings in Artificial Agents*.
Supervisor: Tatjana Nazir.

Bachelor of Psychology Lille, France
University of Lille 2018 – 2020

- Highest honours ([certificate](#)).
- Project: *Emotional Facial Micro-Expressions in Alzheimer’s Disease*.
Supervisor: Loris Schiaratura.

Pre-clinical Medical Studies Lille, France
School of Medicine, University of Lille 2016 – 2018

Research Experience

Research Engineer Lille, France
SCALab – Cognitive and Affective Sciences Lab, University of Lille 2021 – 2022

- Study design for the SOBARAG project (cerebral and physiological differences in social dominance and the creation of social hierarchy towards robots).

Research Intern

SCALab – Cognitive and Affective Sciences Lab, University of Lille

Lille, France

2021 – 2022

- Project: physiological variations during the observation of different types of gestures.
- Experimental set-up and physiological data collection with BIOPAC and EyeLink.

Visiting Research Intern

Neuropsychophysiology Lab, University of Minho

Braga, Portugal

Aug. – Sept. 2022

- Study design for the SOBARAG project; funded by a French government mobility grant.

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant in Psychology

University of Canterbury

Christchurch, NZ

2023 – 2025

- PSYC208 *Cognition* (200-level) 2023 – 2025
- PSYC215 *Introductory Cognitive and Behavioural Neuroscience* (200-level) 2024
- PSYC373 *Neuroscience and Neurological Disorders* (300-level) 2025

Clinical Experience

Neuropsychologist

Memory Clinic, Hospital of Béthune-Bewvry

Béthune, France

Mar. – Aug. 2026

- Neuropsychological assessment of adults and older adults referred for cognitive complaints in geriatrics and neurology.
- Clinical interviews and anamnesis, test administration and interpretation, written neuropsychological reports, and feedback to patients and families.

Neuropsychologist

Hospital of Boulogne-sur-Mer

Boulogne-sur-Mer, France

Sept. – Oct. 2022

- Cognitive and neuropsychological assessments with older adults.

Clinical Internship in Neuropsychology

Memory Clinic (Geriatrics), Hospital of Douai

Douai, France

2021 – 2022

- Neuropsychological assessment; interviews and anamnesis; report writing and feedback.

Clinical Internship in Neuropsychology

Department of Paediatric Oncology (Brain Tumours), Gustave Roussy Institute

Villejuif, France

- Neuropsychological assessment of children and adolescents with brain tumours.

Publications

10 outputs (2023–2026), mostly first-authored, in venues including ACM/IEEE HRI, International Journal of Social Robotics, Frontiers in Robotics and AI, and PLOS ONE.

2026

- [1] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Andrew Vonasch, and Christoph Bartneck. “Too Good to Be True: People Reject Free Gifts from Robots Because They Infer Bad Intentions”. In: *International Journal of Social Robotics* 18.5 (2026), p. 58. ISSN: 1875-4805. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12369-026-01395-x>.
- [2] Maria Teresa Parreira et al. “Responsible Outcomes and Operational Tools for Sustainability in HRI (ROOTS-HRI)”. In: *Companion Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI Companion '26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 1423–1425. ISBN: 9798400723216. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3776734.3793850>.
- [3] **Benjamin Lebrun**. “The Perception of Phantom Costs in HRI”. In: *Companion Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI Companion '26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 1302–1304. ISBN: 9798400723216. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3776734.3794621>.

- [4] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Christoph Bartneck, and Andrew J. Vonasch. “The Role of Agent’s Anthropomorphism in Shaping Phantom Costs”. In: *Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI ’26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 963–971. ISBN: 9798400721281. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757279.3788659>.
- [5] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Christoph Bartneck, and Andrew Vonasch. “Plausible Explanations Reduce Phantom Cost Perception in HRI”. In: *Proceedings of the 21st ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI ’26. Edinburgh, Scotland, UK: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 1278–1282. ISBN: 9798400721281. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757279.3788804>.
- [6] **Benjamin Lebrun** and Andrew Vonasch. “The perception of phantom costs and personalized HRI”. In: *Reference Module in Materials Science and Materials Engineering*. Elsevier, 2026. ISBN: 978-0-12-803581-8. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-443-29266-8.00003-7>.

2025

- [7] **Benjamin Lebrun** et al. *People Perceive More Phantom Costs From Autonomous Agents When They Make Unreasonably Generous Offers*. Preprint. 2025. arXiv: [2511.07401](https://arxiv.org/abs/2511.07401) [cs.HC].
- [8] **Benjamin Lebrun**, Christoph Bartneck, and Andrew Vonasch. “Phantom Costs in Human-Robot Interaction: A Replication Study”. In: *Proceedings of the 2025 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction*. HRI ’25. Melbourne, Australia: IEEE Press, 2025, pp. 1037–1041.

2024

- [9] **Benjamin Lebrun** et al. “Detecting the corruption of online questionnaires by artificial intelligence”. In: *Frontiers in Robotics and AI* 10 (2024). ISSN: 2296-9144. DOI: [10.3389/frobt.2023.1277635](https://doi.org/10.3389/frobt.2023.1277635).

2023

- [10] Tatjana A. Nazir, **Benjamin Lebrun**, and Bing Li. “Improving the acceptability of social robots: Make them look different from humans”. In: *PLOS ONE* 18.11 (2023), e0287507. ISSN: 1932-6203. DOI: [10.1371/journal.pone.0287507](https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0287507).

Work in Progress

◦ Journal article, <i>International Journal of Social Robotics</i>	<i>Under review</i>
◦ Full paper, ACM/IEEE HRI 2027	<i>Under review</i>
◦ Full paper, ACM/IEEE HRI 2027	<i>Under review</i>
◦ Late-Breaking Report, ACM/IEEE HRI	<i>In preparation</i>
◦ Book: <i>An Introduction to Neuroscience in Human-Robot Interaction</i>	<i>In preparation</i>

Presentations

Invited Talks

◦ The Perception of Phantom Costs in HRI Internet Technology and Data Science Lab, Ghent University	<i>Ghent, Belgium June 2026</i>
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Oral Presentations

◦ The Role of Agent’s Anthropomorphism in Shaping Phantom Costs Symposium for Young Researchers in Cognitive Science	<i>Lille, France May 2026</i>
◦ The Perception of Phantom Costs in HRI ACM/IEEE HRI 2026 <i>Also presented as a poster and a video.</i>	<i>Edinburgh, UK March 2026</i>
◦ The Role of Agent’s Anthropomorphism in Shaping Phantom Costs ACM/IEEE HRI 2026	<i>Edinburgh, UK March 2026</i>

- **Phantom Costs Perception in HRI** *Christchurch, NZ*
September 2025
CSSE Postgraduate Conference 2025, University of Canterbury
2nd Place, Best Presentation Award.
- **Phantom Costs in HRI: A Replication Study** *Melbourne, Australia*
March 2025
ACM/IEEE HRI 2025
Short talk; also presented as a poster.

Posters

- **Plausible Explanations Reduce Phantom Cost Perception in HRI** *Edinburgh, UK*
March 2026
ACM/IEEE HRI 2026
- **Too Good to Be True: People Reject Free Gifts from Robots Because They Infer Bad Intentions** *Christchurch, NZ*
September 2024
New Zealand Psychological Society Conference
- **Epistemic Vigilance in HRI** *Christchurch, NZ*
August 2024
Exhibit Your Thesis, University of Canterbury
- **Improving the Acceptability of Social Robots** *Lille, France*
August 2022
European Society for Cognitive Psychology (ESCP 2022) and Embodied and Situated Language Processing (ESLP 2022)

Funding, Grants, and Scholarships

HRI 2027 Pioneers Workshop (2026–2027): co-obtained workshop funding of **US\$ XXX** as General Chair (US\$3,000 from AIJ).

University of Canterbury Doctoral Scholarship (2023–2026): **NZ\$32,000 per year** for the duration of the PhD.

Research Mobility Grant (2022): **€1,350 for two months**, French government “Investissements d’avenir” programme, managed by the National Research Agency (ANR).

Prizes and Awards

- **2026** – Student Volunteer Award: Day Captain | ACM/IEEE HRI 2026
- **2025** – 2nd Place, Best Presentation Award | CSSE Postgraduate Conference, University of Canterbury
- **2025** – Honourable Mention, Pioneers Paper | HRI 2025 (“Skepticism about Robots’ Implausible Statements”)
- **2024** – Research Student Publication Prize | University of Canterbury

Service and Leadership

Conference Organising Committees

- **HRI 2027** – General Chair, HRI Pioneers Workshop (doctoral workshop) *Santa Clara, USA*
– Lead the programme, committee, fundraising, and visual identity.
- **HRI 2025** – Student Volunteer Chair *Melbourne, Australia*
- **HRI 2024** – Student Volunteer Chair *Boulder, Colorado, USA*
– At both conferences, managed a team of 20+ student volunteers: assigned tasks and shifts, briefed and supervised volunteers on site, and acted as the link between SV and the OC to ensure the smooth running of the conference.

Conference Volunteering and Support

- **HRI 2026** – Student Volunteer (Day Captain) *Edinburgh, UK*
- **ESLP 2022** – Support Staff *Lille, France*

Workshops

- **HRI Pioneers 2026** – Selected participant (competitive doctoral workshop for outstanding researchers in their fields) *Edinburgh, UK*

- **HRI 2026** – Co-organiser, workshop “Responsible Outcomes and Operational Tools for Sustainability in HRI”

Edinburgh, UK

Peer Review

- **ACM/IEEE HRI**: 1AC ×5; Reviewer ×7
- **International Conference on Human-Agent Interaction (HAI)**: 1AC ×1; Reviewer ×5
- **International Journal of Social Robotics**: Reviewer ×4
- **Australian Conference on HCI (OzCHI)**: Reviewer ×3
- **ACM Transactions on Human-Robot Interaction**: Reviewer ×1
- **Affective Computing and Intelligent Interaction (ACII)**: Reviewer ×1

Academic Leadership and Outreach

- **President, Master’s Alumni Association**, University of Lille *2021 – 2022*
- **Cognitive Science Forum**, France *March 2022*
 - Represented and presented the Master’s programme (University of Lille).
 - Presented my research conducted in France and Portugal on the SOBARAG project.

Media Coverage

- **CNRS** – “[Less human robots are more readily accepted](#)”
- **University of Canterbury News** – “[Online surveys under threat: how AI can corrupt society](#)”
- **Inside Government NZ** – “[Canterbury researchers find bot-spotting lacking](#)”

Skills

- **Research methods**: Factorial experimental design, large-sample online experiments (Prolific, Qualtrics), simulation-based power analysis, psychometrics, physiological data collection (BIOPAC, EyeLink).
- **Analysis & software**: R, jamovi, G*Power, PsychoPy, E-Prime, MATLAB (certificate: Introduction to Programming with MATLAB), HTML, $\text{\LaTeX}$.
- **Clinical assessment**: Adult, geriatric, and paediatric neuropsychological assessment; social cognition and theory of mind (mini-SEA, faux pas, false belief, emotion recognition); clinical reporting.
- **Languages**: French (native), English (fluent), Portuguese (good), German (previously fluent).

Membership

- ACM Professional Member

Interests

- Collecting meteorites, fossils, and minerals | Former member of the Société Astronomique de France
- Running, hiking, photography, latte art

Referees

Andrew Vonasch
 PhD Main Supervisor
 University of Canterbury
 Psychology, Speech and Hearing
[Email](#)

Christoph Bartneck
 PhD Co-Supervisor
 University of Canterbury
 Computer Science & Software Eng.
[Email](#)

Tatjana Nazir
 Master’s Thesis Supervisor
 University of Lille
 SCALab
[Email](#)